

DELHI While ordinary folks use the festive season to celebrate, for politicians it is the perfect time to market themselves. From the prime minister to opposition leaders, everyone takes time off from onerous duties to cultivate and reap future rewards. Here's how they do it:

■ **Manmohan Singh** holds Iftaar at Race Course Road where the ubiquitous Sonia Gandhi adds some colour. No Prakash Karat but Sitaram Yechury is there. Singh also hosts a tea on Women's Day, but seasoned party goers say A.B. Vajpayee's used to be more fun. May have something to do with the fact that the former prime minister is a bachelor.

■ **Ram Vilas Paswan** offers great biryani and kebabs at his Iftaar. The political turnout varies with his fortunes.

■ **Sandeep Dixit** prefers a dandiya party during Navratras at Talkatora Gardens with Gujarati cui-



Let's Go Party Tonight

sine. He even does the garba in traditional gear.

■ **Shahnawaz Hussein** has added an Eid lunch to his annual Iftaar. Sundry BJP leaders make an appearance to brush up their secular image.

■ **Suresh Kalmadi** doesn't need a season or reason to throw a party. Then proceeds to exhibit amazing

grace on the dance floor.

■ **Murli Manohar Joshi** doesn't play with any colour except saffron. He sticks to a tea party on Holi eve. L.K. Advani's appearance depends on Joshi's latest salvo against him.

■ **Vijay Goel** brings the delicacies of Chandni Chowk to Lutyen's Delhi with stalls of paranthas

and chaat every winter. All the fuss without the mess.

■ **M.A. Naqvi** begins the New Year with a Rampuri lunch and ghazals.

■ **Sachin Pilot** is carrying forward his father's tradition of hosting an annual kisaan lunch. On the menu is *makke di roti* and *sarson ka saag*. Of course, the only farmers present are some of the capital's elite farmhouse owners.

by Priya Sahgal

THE BUZZ OF THE WEEK

Ever since rumours began of an impending reshuffle, Cabinet hopefuls have decided to stay put in Delhi until October 26. Why October 26? Because in this season of travel, both Sonia Gandhi and Manmohan Singh are in Delhi till then.

VOICES



"I am a politician by accident. I did not choose politics as a career."

Manmohan Singh, prime minister

"I have never believed in communal politics and have been wrongly painted as a communal leader. This minority-majority talk has destroyed the nation."

Narendra Modi, Gujarat chief minister

"The name of the family or the experience of the family gives you a headstart, it helps you in making a beginning. But in our democratic system, you have to prove yourself."

Sonia Gandhi, Congress president

"We are in a drift and the Communist parties are anchors. They want to make sure that the drift is not that fast, and hopefully the anchor will let the ship sail."

Kapil Sibal, Union minister for science and technology

"Whatever the Australians do does not figure in the picture, but whatever the Indians do is examined under a microscope."

S. Sreesanth, cricketer

